We notice that the third stage has two variants: either 'yellow' splits away (from 'red' and 'brown'), *or* 'blue' and 'green' (together) split from 'black'; while in the fourth stage, both splits take place: 'yellow' splits (from 'red') *and* 'blue' and 'green' from 'black'.

This fact can be useful in linguistics problems, considering the following aspect: historically speaking, it is likely that some languages had a limited number of colour terms and, in time, due to contact with other nations, they might have borrowed terms for other colours. For this reason, it is likely that, in some languages, some colour terms behave differently from others. In other words, it is likely that there are some basic colours (inherent to the language, which, according to the aforementioned hypothesis, should contain 'white', 'black', and 'red'), which follow the usual declension of the language and other colour terms (borrowings from other languages) with a different flexion (usually diminished, or even inflexible).

For example, in Romanian, the basic colour terms have a full set of inflected forms, with four different forms ('white': *alb – albă – albi – albe*, 'black': *negru – neagră – negri – negre*), while other, new terms, are usually invariable ('pink': *roz*, 'brown': *maro*, 'turquoise': *turcoaz*, etc.).

5.9 Practice problems

Problem 5.9

Ulwa (Peter Arkadiev, TurLom 2003)

Here are some words in Ulwa and their English translations *in random order*:

suulu, *suukilu*, *suumanalu*, *mismatu*, *miskatu*, *onkinayan*, *onkayan*, *onyan*

'bow', 'your$_{SG}$ cat', 'my dog', 'our bow', 'his cat', 'dog', 'his bow', 'your$_{PL}$ dog'

Problem 5.9a Determine the correct correspondences.

Problem 5.9b Translate into English: *suumalu* and *miskanatu*.

Problem 5.9c Translate into Ulwa: 'cat', 'my cat', 'your$_{SG}$ bow', 'their bow'.